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Coralville removes Flock cameras after council votes to end contract

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CORALVILLE, Iowa (KCRG) - The city of Coralville removed its Flock license plate reader cameras Wednesday morning, one day after the city council voted to terminate its contract with



The council originally approved the Flock cameras in September with a stipulation that they would not be used to help find undocumented immigrants. Coralville Police Chief Kyle Nicholson said at the time that the department would not cooperate with federal immigration requests unless presented with a subpoena.

“Flock will not be used on the sole basis to enforce immigration law. So if ICE is requesting access to our data, it’s a no,” Chief Nicholson said.

In December, the Iowa Attorney General’s Office sent a letter to the city stating its Flock camera policy was in violation of Iowa law. That law prohibits local entities from impeding immigration enforcement. The attorney general’s office ordered the city to remove the immigration stipulation from its policy or risk losing state funding.

Rather than amend the policy, the city council voted on a resolution to stop using the cameras entirely.

A number of community members spoke against the cameras before Tuesday’s vote, citing privacy concerns. During the meeting, some in the crowd laughed when council member Rich Vogelzang defended the cameras and said other cities had success using them.

“They understand that law abiding persons do not need to be concerned about having license plate reader cameras in their community,” Vogelzang said.

Chief Nicholson said the Flock cameras had already helped multiple cases get solved.

“The cameras contributed to several successful investigations, including locating stolen vehicles and identifying individuals involved in hit-and-run accidents. In multiple cases, the technology helped us identify and charge suspects who committed crimes in Coralville,” Chief Nicholson said. “In several instances, we would not have been able to move cases forward without the connecting evidence obtained through the cameras,” he said.

Council member Hai Huynh said support for the cameras existed but was outweighed by opposition.

“Minute compared to the number that is against it. So I do agree with you that there are community members out there that do support this. But right now — the majority of Coralville residents is against it,” Huynh said.

Chief Nicholson said the deactivation of the cameras is a loss.

“The cameras were a tool that made our staff more effective and efficient in solving crimes. From an operational standpoint, their removal is a loss for the department,” Chief Nicholson said.

But the Chief said the department respects the council’s decision to terminate the contract with Flock.

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